



M. M. SOMAYA

Former India hockey captain and 1980
Moscow Olympics gold medal winner



JUDICIOUS EXPOSURE TO **KEY** **PLAYERS** CRITICAL IN PARIS BUILD-UP

A podium finish in 2024 Olympics would need a **virtuoso performance**.

A whirlwind start and the 'Ultimate Showdown' promise to make 2024 an exciting one for hockey buffs.

In January, a tour of South Africa for the Indian men offers coach Craig Fulton a last opportunity to experiment with players, combinations, and tactics. Also in February, the FIH Pro League (FPL) commences, stretching to June. And in the twinkling of an eye in July-August, the showpiece event, the Paris Olympics, would be upon us. World No. 3-ranked India will have to pace themselves intelligently through this packed schedule to retain the coveted spot among the elite. Judicious exposure to key players and saving the best for Paris are critical.

A quick reality check outside of Asia shows where this year's action will be. Germany and Holland groomed young teams at the last World Cup and yet finished on the podium in positions one and three. An ageing Belgium remain a potent force. Great Britain, Spain, and even France are playing at a higher level. Australia have declined a bit in the world rankings but can never be counted out. So, away from Asia, the competition looks ominous. A podium finish in Paris would need a virtuoso performance.

India have some world-class players to pull it off. Harmanpreet Singh, Hardik Singh, Manpreet Singh, and P.R. Sreejesh comprise the quartet that gives solidity to the side. On the big days, you can rely on them to step up and be counted. Flair and creativity on the frontline are manifest every time Abhishek is on the ball. Lalit Upadhyay has similar abilities and can sidestep opponents to create openings. Amit Rohidas, Nilakanta Sharma, Shamsheer Singh, and Sukhjot Singh run the hard yards in midfield. Overall, it is a balanced line-up. A sure-shot striker would make it a complete team. Mandeep Singh, Akashdeep Singh, Karthi Selvam, and Dilpreet Singh have been around for a while now, and their marksmanship will have to be a notch higher and more consistent. Inculcating the knack of delivering a

knockout punch upfront and establishing an impervious left side of defence could be occupying a lot of Fulton's thinking time.

In January again, our women's team will be looking to book a berth for Paris. A recent win at the Asian Champions Trophy in Ranchi has infused confidence. Familiarity with the conditions in Ranchi would hopefully hold them in good stead at the Olympic Qualifier. Seeing off strong teams like Germany, New Zealand, Japan, and Chile and securing one of the three berths to Paris will be a priority for India.

Keeper Savita Punia has been a strong performer and an inspirational leader. A host of players have impressed. Salima Tete is the pick of the bunch with her loping stride and sublime stick skills. Battle-hardened Vandana Katariya and deceptive Neha have been sprightly. Nikki Pradhan and Monika Malik have brought a semblance of stability in defence. However, the midfielder's role in stitching together the moves and inducing cohesiveness would have to be more pronounced. Coach Janneke Schopman would have this top of mind as the team braces for the Olympic Qualifier. Qualification would considerably uplift morale, and then participation in the FPL would assume a special significance. It would become a preparatory run-up to the Paris Games.

Peak physical condition has been the hallmark of successful Indian men's and women's teams in recent years. The present teams would have to battle injuries and the galloping age of key players to attain the same levels that they were able to attain in Tokyo 2020.

Nurturing a feeder line of players through the junior squad is imperative. A breath of fresh air is the commencement of sub-junior competition at the national level in 2023. Contemporary training and exposure to international competition for these youngsters should ensure consistent results at the international level.

Finally, finding an annual window to conduct the Hockey India League would give flight to new careers and sow seeds for long-term success.